

“For my flesh is true food, and my blood is true drink.” (*English Standard Version*, John 6:55).

Until the Protestant Reformation, all Christians understood that the celebration of Communion was a supernatural event. The elements of bread and wine are consecrated to become the real Body and Blood of Christ. Huldrych Zwingli, a contemporary of Cornelius Hoen, a Dutch theologian, was among the most outspoken of the dissidents of Christ’s real presence in the Eucharist. According to Zwingli and Hoen, the words of Christ’s institution “this is my body” (“hoc est corpus meum”) were meant to be understood symbolically rather than literally.

“This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me.” (*ESV*, 1 Corinthians 11:24).

Zwingli’s beliefs gained notable attention throughout the Protestant Reformation. In 1525, Martin Luther, the insurgent Augustinian friar, condemned Zwingli’s views of the Eucharist. This Eucharistic conflict persisted until 1529 when both parties sought to settle the dispute at the Marburg Colloquy. The dispute, however, was not settled when Luther refused to concede the real presence of Christ in the elements of Communion.

Zwingli and his followers, influenced by the rationalisms of Thomas Aquinas, a Doctor of the Roman Catholic Church, could not understand how the elements of bread and wine could ever transform into or even contain the Body and Blood of Jesus. Luther and his followers, however, accepted this as a mystery of Christian doctrine which need not be rationalized.

Zwingli was the first religious leader to ever confess the Eucharist to be a purely symbolic memorial of Christ’s sacrifice.

In the East, the Orthodox Churches have never made any detailed declaration of the nature of the Eucharist, instead understanding it to be a mystery of Christ’s revelation. However, the Orthodox Church has always affirmed, “[the Eucharist] is strictly understood as being the real presence of Christ, His true Body and Blood mystically present in the bread and wine which are offered to the Father in his name and consecrated by the divine Spirit of God.” (Orthodox Church in America, Volume II, Sacraments, Holy Eucharist).

In the West, the Roman Catholic Church officially defined its belief of transubstantiation at the Fourth Lateran Council in 1215. “His body and blood are truly contained in the sacrament of the altar under the forms of bread and wine, the bread and wine having been changed in substance, by God’s power, into his body and blood,” (Fourth Lateran Council, 1. Confession of Faith).

Followers of Luther staunchly stood against Zwingli’s symbolic understanding of the Eucharist. Luther himself wrote in his Small Catechism, “The Sacrament of the Altar is the true body and blood of our Lord Jesus Christ under the bread and wine, for us Christians to eat and to drink, instituted by Christ Himself.” A few decades later, the Book of Concord, affirmed by confessional Lutherans, affirms real presence doctrine, “[T]he true body and blood of Christ are truly present in the Holy Supper under the form of bread and wine, and are there dispensed and received; and the contrary doctrine is rejected,” (The Formula of Concord: Solid Declaration, VII).

The Book of Concord outright rejects Zwingli's symbolic rationalization of the Eucharist, "We reject and condemn as false, erroneous, and misleading all Sacramentarian opinions and doctrines which are not in accordance with, but contrary and opposed to, the doctrine... founded upon God's Word... that Christ has not promised the true, essential presence of His body and blood in His Supper," (The Formula of Concord: Solid Declaration, VII).

The real presence and importance of the Eucharist was also affirmed by many, if not all of the earliest Church Fathers. If one is to follow Zwingli's symbolic approach to the Sacrament, he must either reject the teachings of the most exalted early Church Fathers or he must interpret all of their teachings to be meant figuratively. According to Zwingli's interpretation, none of these earliest Church Fathers ever properly described the literal, symbolic nature of the Eucharist.

Augustine of Hippo

Augustine (354 AD - 430 AD), bishop of Hippo, is one of the most influential theologians of the Western Church. As a convert to Christianity, his views on grace, free will, the Trinity propagated through his famous writings established him as the preeminent philosopher of the Early Church. He has been commemorated as a Doctor of the Roman Catholic Church and is revered as a Saint in both Eastern and Western Christendom.

"So what you can see, then, is bread and a cup; that's what even your eyes tell you; but as for what your faith asks to be instructed about, the bread is the body of Christ, the cup the blood of Christ." (Augustine, Sermon 272).

Augustine wrote to the Infantes that the elements of the Eucharist which are received as a Church during Communion is, despite its earthly appearance, the Body and Blood of Christ. The Church knows this with confidence through faith. One must not apply his own human perception and reason into his belief of the Sacrament, but rather the truth of the Sacrament revealed by Christ.

"That bread which you can see on the altar, sanctified by the word of God, is the body of Christ. That cup, or rather what the cup contains, sanctified by the word of God, is the blood of Christ." (Augustine, Sermon 227).

Earlier, Augustine also wrote to the Infantes that the elements of Communion visible in the appearance of bread and wine, when consecrated, is indeed the Body and Blood of Christ. He makes no allusion to any symbolic form of the Eucharist.

Jerome of Stridon

Jerome (c. 347 AD - 420 AD), the renowned author of the Latin Vulgate translation of the Bible, was a hermetic scholar of the Patristic Era. Having been faced with countless temptations living in large cities (prior to his hermetic life), Jerome often taught about avoidance of temptation and Christian purity in his other writings. He too has been commemorated as a Doctor of the Roman Catholic Church and is revered as a Saint in many Christian traditions.

“After the type had been fulfilled by the Passover celebration and He had eaten the flesh of the lamb with His Apostles, He takes bread which strengthens the heart of man, and goes on to the true Sacrament of the Passover, so that just as Melchisedech, the priest of the Most High God, in prefiguring Him, made bread and wine an offering, He too makes Himself manifest in the reality of His own Body and Blood.” (Jerome, Commentaries on the Gospel of Matthew).

In his commentary on the Gospel account of Matthew, Jerome likens Communion to the Passover feast, at which the Jews would eat the sacrificial paschal lamb (Exodus 12:5, 8). The meat of the lamb was eaten with unleavened bread, untainted by yeast. Like the stainless lamb, Christ too was made a perfect sacrifice for the whole world. As Jerome understood, we too must partake in the feast of our literal sacrificial lamb. Jerome’s commentary on the Eucharist ends with his affirmation of the real manifestation of Christ in the offering of Communion.

John Chrysostom

John Chrysostom (c. 347 AD - 407 AD) was a patriarch of Constantinople who used the Scriptures to clearly preach truth through his treatises and public homilies. In Greek, his title “Chrysostom” literally means “Golden-mouthed,” whose authentic teachings are purely shown through his sermons against abusive authorities, pagans, sodomites, and Judaizers. He is venerated as one of the Three Holy Hierarchs of the Eastern Orthodox Church, and is a Doctor of the Roman Catholic Church. He is also revered as a saint in other branches of Eastern and Western Churches.

“Since then the word says, ‘This is My Body,’ let us both be persuaded and believe, and look at it with the eyes of the mind. For Christ has given nothing sensible, but though in things sensible yet all to be perceived by the mind,” (Chrysostom, Homilies on the Gospel of Matthew, 82).

The natural mind can not use reason to comprehend the supernatural. What the eyes see as bread and wine are sensibly figured to be bread and wine. However, with a lens of faith in Christ’s divine power, the mind can believe that the bread and wine are consecrated to be His Body and Blood after the words of institution are professed.

“For it is not a man who causes the elements that are set forth to become the Body and Blood of Christ, but Christ Himself, Who was crucified for our sake. Fulfilling the figure, the priest stands and utters the words. But the power and

grace belong to God. 'This is My Body,' the priest says. The words transform the elements set forth," (Chrysostom, Homily on the Betrayal of Judas).

John Chrysostom comments on the finale of the Gospel of Matthew by describing Judas's treachery against the Body of Christ, both divine and mortal. He describes the relation between the Last Supper and the common consecration of Communion, noting that it is the same Body of Christ that was crucified which is offered in the Sacrament of the Altar. He ends his statement with a profession of the transformation of the bread and wine into this Body and Blood.

Epiphanius of Salamis

Epiphanius (c. 315 AD - 403 AD), bishop of Salamis, was an ascetic monk before his episcopal nomination. Throughout his life, he taught simplicity within Christian doctrines, straying from unnecessary luxuries which could get in the way of his life in Christ. He is best known for writing the *Panarion*, a comprehensive history of Christianity and heresies from the first three centuries. He is honored as a Saint in Eastern and Western Christendom.

"We see that the Saviour took [something] in His hands, as it is in the Gospel, when He was reclining at the supper; and He took this, and giving thanks, He said: 'This is really Me.' And He gave to His disciples and said: 'This is really Me.' And we see that It is not equal nor similar, not to the incarnate image, not to the invisible divinity, not to the outline of His limbs. For It is round of shape, and devoid of feeling. As to Its power, He means to say even of Its grace, 'This is really Me.'; and none disbelieves His word. For anyone who does not believe the truth in what He says is deprived of grace and of a Savior." (Epiphanius, *Ancoratus*).

Epiphanius recalls the Gospels when, on the night He was betrayed, Christ took bread for His disciples, gave thanks, and broke it for each of them. As He did so, He declared that the bread is really Himself, Christ, in the Flesh. Of course, Epiphanius admits that the element of bread looks, feels, and tastes like bread. Obviously the consecrated bread has not observably changed in its sensory characteristics so the Flesh retains the physicality of its host. Christ pronounces the host to be His Flesh. To deny Christ's statement of His sacrificial Sacrament, doubting that His Flesh miraculously takes on the form of its host, Epiphanius says, is to deny Christ's divinity and sacrifice altogether.

Ambrose of Milan

Ambrose (c. 340 AD - 397 AD) was a Roman governor near Milan who was voted into the bishopric of Milan during the height of the Arian controversy. As bishop, he took an aggressive position against Arius, condemning the Christological heresies which Arius taught. Ambrose has been accredited as the inventor of antiphonal, or "Ambrosian," chant. He was a notable

influence on Augustine and, like Augustine, has been commemorated as a Doctor of the Roman Catholic Church and is revered as a Saint in the East and throughout the West.

“Why do you seek the order of nature in the Body of Christ, seeing that the Lord Jesus Himself was born of a Virgin, not according to nature? It is the true Flesh of Christ which crucified and buried, this is then truly the Sacrament of His Body.” (Ambrose, *On the Mysteries*).

In Chapter IX of his writing on the mysteries of the Christian faith, Ambrose condemns those who distrust Christ’s true presence in the Sacrament. Ambrose makes it clear that the blessing of the bread and wine truly changes the nature of the elements through a divine mystery. By faith the Church is confident that Christ was the son of a virgin. So also the Church is confident that Christ has truly manifested Himself in the elements of bread and wine. The principles of nature and of human understanding have no precedence in Christ’s miraculous presence in the Sacrament.

Gregory of Nyssa

Gregory (c. 335 AD - 395 AD) was a bishop in Nyssa within the pagan region of Cappadocia. He is known as one of the three Cappadocian Fathers, the other two being Basil of Caesarea and Gregory of Nazianzus. He is best remembered in the Church for promoting the concept of Triadism (in relation to the distinctness of the Trinity) and, despite his influence from Origen, the concept of the infinity of God (whereas Origen taught that God was limited and not infinite). He, with the other two Cappadocian Fathers, is a respected Saint in both Eastern and Western traditions of Christianity.

“For that Body was, as to its potency, bread; but it has been consecrated by the lodging there of the Word, who pitched His tent in the flesh,” (Gregory, *Great Catechism*, 37).

Gregory likens the Eucharistic mystery to the mystery of the Incarnation. Just as the eternal Logos resided in the Flesh as an incarnate man, so also does He reside in the Flesh in the panary throne of the host. Such comparisons to the Incarnation invalidate any argument that God, an infinite being, can not reside in finite material. To say that the finite can not contain the infinite not only denies power from God, who has infinite power, but also denies Christ’s Incarnation and simultaneous divinity and humanity.

“The bread again is at first common bread; but when the mystery sanctifies it, it is called and actually becomes the Body of Christ,” (Gregory, *Orations and Sermons*, IX).

Gregory notes the nature of the consecrated bread as the actual Body of Christ. The bread is not merely symbolic and is not simply referred to as His Body, but actually, through the divine mystery of consecration, truly becomes the Body.

Cyril of Jerusalem

Cyril (c. 313 AD - 386 AD), bishop of Jerusalem, was a theologian in the Patristic Era who is best known for his “Catecheses.” He was a participant of the First Council of Constantinople (381 AD) who voted in favor of the term “homousios” to describe the consubstantial relationship between the Father and the Son. Although he may have started out his episcopate semi-Arian in his theology, he would later accept Nicene doctrine and was a public enemy of the Arian bishop Acacius. He is commemorated as a Doctor of the Roman Catholic Church, and is honored as a Saint in many Christian traditions, predominantly in the East.

“Since then He Himself declared and said of the Bread, ‘This is My Body,’ who shall dare to doubt any longer? And since He has Himself affirmed and said, ‘This is My Blood,’ who shall ever hesitate, saying, that it is not His blood?” (Cyril, Catechetical Lecture 22, 1).

Cyril notes the simplicity in Jesus’s verba at the Last Supper. Because Christ plainly stated the nature of the bread and the nature of the wine, the bread and the wine must undoubtedly be the Body and Blood He declared them to be.

“Consider therefore the Bread and the Wine not as bare elements, for they are, according to the Lord's declaration, the Body and Blood of Christ; for even though sense suggests this to you, yet let faith establish you. Judge not the matter from the taste, but from faith be fully assured without misgiving, that the Body and Blood of Christ have been vouchsafed to you.” (Cyril, Catechetical Lecture 22, 6).

“Having learned these things, and been fully assured that the seeming bread is not bread, though sensible to taste, but the Body of Christ; and that the seeming wine is not wine, though the taste will have it so, but the Blood of Christ,” (Cyril, Catechetical Lecture 22, 9).

The elements of Communion were, as previously stated, declared by Christ to be His own Body and Blood. Of course, the Eucharist might look like and taste like the hosts of bread and wine which they indeed once were. However, Cyril is confident through his faith in Christ’s word that the elements are exactly what Christ says they are. The elements do not simply symbolize the spiritual presence of Christ with His Church, but in fact are the uncompromising covenant which Christ established. The elements, consecrated, are the literal matter of Flesh and Blood, despite their physical appearance and taste.

“After this ye hear the chanter inviting you with a sacred melody to the communion of the Holy Mysteries, and saying, ‘O taste and see that the Lord is good.’ Trust not the judgment to your bodily palate no, but to faith unfaltering; for

they who taste are bidden to taste, not bread and wine, but the anti-typical Body and Blood of Christ.” (Cyril, Catechetical Lecture 23, 20).

How is one supposed to trust that the elements of Communion become the true Body and Blood of Jesus? By faith alone the Church is called to trust in this miraculous mystery. No human has the authority to judge Christ’s presence in the Sacrament -- that is a judgment for God to make. Since God has already made His declaration, humanity must have faith in His declaration.

Athanasius of Alexandria

Athanasius (c. 293 AD - 373 AD), the famous Trinitarian bishop of Alexandria, staunchly defended orthodox Christology against widespread heresy and defilement. He served as deacon at the First Council of Nicaea where he severely debated the heretic Arius. Due to his controversial statements, he was exiled numerous times and was at odds with multiple Roman Emperors. He was also the first person known to list the complete canon of the New Testament. Subsequent to his death, he was praised by Gregory of Nazianzus as being the “pillar of the Church.” He has been commemorated as a Doctor of the Roman Catholic Church and is revered as a Saint in both Eastern and Western Christendom.

“You shall see the Levites [priests] bringing loaves and a cup of wine, and placing them on the table. So long as the prayers of supplication and entreaties have not been made, there is only bread and wine. But after the great and wonderful prayers have been completed, the bread is become the Body, and the wine the Blood, of our Lord Jesus Christ. And again: Let us approach the celebration of the mysteries. The bread and the wine, so long as the prayers and the supplications have not taken place, remain simply what they are. But after the great prayers and holy supplications have been set forth, the Word comes down into the bread and wine--and thus is the Body confected.” (Athanasius, Sermon to the Newly Baptized).

From a fragment of his catechetical Sermon to the Newly Baptized, Athanasius is clear that the consecrated elements of Communion are supernaturally vested with the Body and Blood of Christ. By a divine miracle, the elements remain natural bread and wine until the words of institution. Christ, as High Priest, perpetuates His sacrifice on the cross being the same High Priest and the same Paschal victim (even if the miracle is performed through the clergy). By Christ’s Word, God comes down on the bread and wine. The bread and wine are no longer simply bread and wine, but hosts of the Logos. Christ becomes eternally incarnate through His one eternal sacrifice.

Hilary of Poitiers

Hilary (c. 310 AD - c. 367 AD), bishop of Poitiers, was born to a pagan family. After study of the Christian Scriptures, he renounced his idolatry and professed the truth of God. Regarded as the “Athanasius of the West,” Hilary was exiled for his zeal against the Arian heresy. He has been commemorated as a Doctor of the Roman Catholic Church and is revered as a Saint in most Churches, especially in the West.

“For as to what we say concerning the reality of Christ's nature within us, unless we have been taught by Him, our words are foolish and impious. For He says Himself, ‘My flesh is meat indeed, and My blood is drink indeed. He that eats My flesh and drinks My blood abides in Me, and I in him.’ As to the verity of the flesh and blood there is no room left for doubt. For now both from the declaration of the Lord Himself and our own faith, it is verily flesh and verily blood.” (Hilary, On the Trinity XIII, 14).

Without Christ’s right teachings, the Church is misguided from pious truth. Christ said that His Flesh is indeed true food, and His Blood likewise is true drink. He stated this clearly to His disciples without reservation, so man can not doubt the true substance of the Body and Blood. If Christ had only meant that His Body and Blood were only symbolized in the food and drink, then He would have stated this teaching differently. Rather, He simply said that His Body and Blood were indeed food and drink -- nothing else. The Church would be foolish to teach otherwise.

Cyprian of Carthage

Cyprian (c. 210 AD - 258 AD), bishop of Carthage, was a North African convert and prominent Latin religious author. He controversially denounced Novatianism, a heresy which refused Communion to Christians who denied their faith under pressure of the Roman Empire. He lived during the Plague of Cyprian, an affliction which bears his name for his specific descriptions of it. For his martyrdom, he is honored as a Saint throughout Christendom, especially in the West.

“Also, the sacrament of the passover contains nothing else in the law of the Exodus than that the lamb which is slain in the figure of Christ should be eaten in one house. God speaks, saying, ‘In one house shall you eat it; you shall not send its flesh abroad from the house.’ The flesh of Christ, and the holy of the Lord, cannot be sent abroad, nor is there any other home to believers but the one Church.” (Cyprian, On the Unity of the Church).

Cyprian likens the Sacrament of the Eucharist to the Paschal lamb of Passover. He says that, as the Paschal lamb was slain as a sacrifice and eaten, so too does the Church find unity in the Sacramental covenant which God has prepared as a sacrifice.

Clement of Alexandria

Clement (c. 150 AD - c. 215 AD) was a convert to Christianity who was familiar with many pagan religions and philosophies. He was an instructor at the Catechetical School of Alexandria where he taught his theology and philosophies to forthcoming Christian scholars. Among his disciples were Alexander of Jerusalem and Origen. He is honored as a Saint among Western Christianity and much, though not all, of Eastern Christianity.

“The Word is all to the child, both father and mother and tutor and nurse. ‘Eat my flesh,’ He says, ‘and drink my blood.’ Such is the suitable food which the Lord ministers, and He offers His flesh and pours forth His blood, and nothing is wanting for the children's growth. O amazing mystery!” (Clement, The Paedagogus).

Clement likens the words of institution to words uttered to a child. Although one may not understand the miracle of the Sacrament set before him, he must have child-like confidence in Christ's commands. Christ, who offers His grace through His Flesh and Blood, ministers His Flesh as Blood as food and drink prepared in a banquet for the Church. Clement concludes this statement exclaiming the greatness of this mystery. The Eucharistic mystery is a miracle from the Creator. The mystery need not align with physical laws and understanding, since the miracle comes not from nature, but from the supernatural God.

Irenaeus of Lyons

Irenaeus (c. 130 AD - c. 202 AD) was a Greek bishop in Lyons best known for his work “Against Heresies.” He was a contemporary of Polycarp, who himself was a disciple of the apostle John. Through his writings, he harshly criticized heretics (especially Gnostics) and affirmed orthodox Christian doctrines. He is the earliest Christian source to encounter and acclaim all four Gospels. For his principle pillars of orthodox Christianity, he is regarded as a theological bridge between East and West Christendom. He is soon expected to be commemorated as a Doctor of the Roman Catholic Church, and is honored as a Saint in many Christian traditions.

“He has acknowledged the cup (which is a part of the creation) as His own blood, from which He bedews our blood; and the bread (also a part of the creation) He has established as His own body, from which He gives increase to our bodies.” (Irenaeus, Against Heresies Book V, 2).

The elements of Communion, bread and wine, are a part of God's Creation. The physical materials, however, when consecrated by Christ's words of institution, manifest into His Body and Blood. By faith, one must believe that Christ's words made these elements manifest into what He indeed declared them to be.

“For as the bread, which is produced from the earth, when it receives the invocation of God, is no longer common bread, but the Eucharist, consisting of two realities, earthly and heavenly; so also our bodies, when they receive the

Eucharist, are no longer corruptible, having the hope of the resurrection to eternity.” (Irenaeus, Against Heresies Book IV, 18).

The elements which Christ has declared to be His Body and Blood truly contain His real presence. The Church, with whom Christ has made His covenant and for whom Christ prepares His sacrifice, is made pure, washed by His Blood which is outpoured for many. In this covenant of bread and wine, which manifest Body and Blood by His own words, the Church finds hope for salvation.

Justin Martyr

Justin Martyr (c. 100 AD - c. 165 AD) was a Christian apologist and teacher who adamantly taught Christian ethics and philosophy, especially against pagan Roman criticisms of the first centuries. His apologies and defenses of Christian practices were enough to convince the Roman Emperor Antoninus to refrain from state persecution of Christianity during his reign.

“And this food is called among us Εὐχαριστία [the Eucharist], of which no one is allowed to partake but the man who believes that the things which we teach are true... For not as common bread and common drink do we receive these; but in like manner as Jesus Christ our Saviour, having been made flesh by the Word of God, had both flesh and blood for our salvation, so likewise have we been taught that the food which is blessed by the prayer of His word, and from which our blood and flesh by transmutation are nourished, is the flesh and blood of that Jesus who was made flesh.” (Justin Martyr, First Apology).

Justin Martyr begins his exposition on the Eucharist by stating that only those who affirm the doctrines of the Church, especially those concerning the real presence in the Eucharist itself, may partake of this common Communion. He then defines the Eucharist as having been made Flesh and Blood, and are no longer simply bread or wine. The Church knows that the Flesh and Blood of salvation are indeed food because that is what our Savior taught. Christ, who was made Flesh, has declared our bread to be the living bread of His Body, by which we partake in the Sacramental graces of salvation.

Ignatius of Antioch

Ignatius (c. 35 - c. 108 AD), patriarch of Antioch, with Polycarp, was a friend of the Apostles and a direct disciple of John. On his way to Rome, where he was martyred, Ignatius wrote multiple letters which have been cited as a source of early Christian theology. He is most famous for his ecclesiology and Sacramentology and is revered as a Saint in both Eastern and Western Christendom.

“They abstain from the Eucharist and from prayer, because they confess not the Eucharist to be the flesh of our Saviour Jesus Christ, which suffered for our sins, and which the Father, of His goodness, raised up again. Those, therefore, who speak against this gift of God, incur death in the midst of their disputes.” (Ignatius, Letter to the Smyrnaeans).

In the middle of his letter to the church in Smyrna, Ignatius condemns those who reject God’s grace in a number of ways. One most grievous example of denying God’s grace, he notes, is by denying Christ’s true presence in the Eucharist. The flesh consumed in Communion with the Church is indeed the same flesh which was made sacrifice for the world on the cross. A man who rejects this teaching accepts death and opens his life up to sin.

“I desire the bread of God, the heavenly bread, the bread of life, which is the flesh of Jesus Christ, the Son of God, who became afterwards of the seed of David and Abraham; and I desire the drink of God, namely His blood, which is incorruptible love and eternal life.” (Ignatius, Epistle to the Romans).

In his letter to the Romans, Ignatius expresses his desire for martyrdom. He asks that the Romans do not save him, that he may inherit eternal life. Ignatius expresses faith in his salvation, knowing that God has prepared a pure sacrifice for him. This incorruptible sacrifice is the Flesh of Christ, the Bread of Life. He desires also to drink the Blood of God, which has been made a covenant for the Church. Ignatius is unwavering in his belief that the bread and drink are certainly the Body and Blood of the Son of God.

The Didache

The Didache is one of the earliest written manuscripts of Christian literature. Dated to the early second century or late first century, the Didache (in English, the “Teaching”), is a written treatise of the teachings of the apostles. It briefly describes the Way of Life, the Way of Death, the Lord’s prayer, ethics, Baptism, Communion, and ecclesiology.

“On the Lord’s Day of the Lord come together, break bread and hold Eucharist, after confessing your transgressions that your offering may be pure; but let none who has a quarrel with his fellow join in your meeting until they be reconciled, that your sacrifice be not defiled.” (Didache, XIV).

Although the Didache is a very short manuscript, its writers were sure to explain the practice of the ritual of Communion. While it does not explicitly state that the bread and wine of the Eucharist are indeed the Body and Blood of Christ, the Didache upholds the Eucharist to be a pure sacrifice and offering to the Lord. The pure sacrifice of the Eucharist, of course, is Jesus Christ, the Paschal lamb.

Last Supper

At the Last Supper, Jesus blessed the bread and wine and gave it to His apostles. He told them that the bread they ate was His Body, and that the blood He gave them was surely his Blood.

“²⁶Now as they were eating, Jesus took bread, and after blessing it broke it and gave it to the disciples, and said, ‘Take, eat; this is my body.’ ²⁷And he took a cup, and when he had given thanks he gave it to them, saying, ‘Drink of it, all of you, ²⁸for this is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins.’” (*ESV*, Matthew 26:26-28).

“²²And as they were eating, he took bread, and after blessing it broke it and gave it to them, and said, “Take; this is my body.” ²³And he took a cup, and when he had given thanks he gave it to them, and they all drank of it. ²⁴And he said to them, “This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many.” (*ESV*, Mark 14:22-24).

By these words of institution, Christ initiated the Sacrament of Communion. As He gave His Blood to His apostles, He established a blood-covenant with the Church, His one Body (*ESV*, 1 Corinthians 12:12). On the eve of His crucifixion, He gives meaning to the Passover as Christ passes over from death and Resurrection to His Father for the salvation of all who join in His true Communion. This is the new covenant of mercy experienced by Christians through His blessed Sacrament. Unlike the traditional account of the Jewish Passover where the Jews were saved from death by the sacrifice made in the Paschal lamb, the Passover of Christ saves us from eternal damnation. The covenant of Christ truly is a covenant. Likewise, the consecrated body and bread are truly Flesh and Blood.

“¹⁹And he took bread, and when he had given thanks, he broke it and gave it to them, saying, ‘This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me.’ ²⁰And likewise the cup after they had eaten, saying, ‘This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood.’” (*ESV*, Luke 22:19-20).

According to Luke’s account, the Sacrament is offered in remembrance of Christ. Certainly this is done in remembrance of Christ, as it is instructed. However, this does not mean that the Lord’s Supper serves merely as a memory of Jesus, or some strange cultural tradition. Indeed, the bread and wine are the real Body and Blood of Christ, while the reception of the Sacrament, being the covenant of Christ, serves as a memory of His Passion and Passover. The offering, rather than being simply one initial offering of salvation, is one offering spread for the entire Church throughout the centuries.

The Eucharist, a pure covenant in communion with the Church, is the summary of the Church’s God-given faith.

Bread of Life

In the synagogue at Capernaum, Jesus prepared his apostles for the Eucharist through His words which, as Peter affirmed, solely bring eternal life (*ESV* John 6:68). Through Christ's covenant alone can one find the way to the Father.

“⁴⁸I am the bread of life. ⁴⁹Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died. ⁵⁰This is the bread that comes down from heaven, so that one may eat of it and not die. ⁵¹I am the living bread that came down from heaven. If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever. And the bread that I will give for the life of the world is my flesh.” (*ESV*, John 6:48-51).

“⁵³Truly, truly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood, you have no life in you. ⁵⁴Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up on the last day. ⁵⁵For my flesh is true food, and my blood is true drink. ⁵⁶Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood abides in me, and I in him.” (*ESV*, John 6:53-56).

Christ, the living bread, nourishes us and feeds us. His bread, He says, is His Flesh -- Flesh that would soon be scourged and crucified. He says that His Flesh, the same Flesh which endured His awful Passion, is true food. He says that His Blood, the same Blood of the covenant which would be outpoured for many, is true drink.

“⁶⁰When many of his disciples heard it, they said, ‘This is a hard saying; who can listen to it?’” (*ESV*, John 6:60).

Jesus gave no indication that these are merely symbolic depictions of His Flesh and Blood. In fact, many of his disciples refused to follow Him after these “hard sayings.” These disciples would not have turned away if Christ had not meant literal Flesh and Blood. After all, such a statement would have sounded like cannibalism. However, Christ, the Son of God, the pure Paschal lamb, allowed these disciples to leave knowing that it would be better that they abandon His ministry altogether than continue in refusal to accept His one covenant.

Unworthy Reception

This Communion, however, can actually be harmful to partake if done so wrongly. In a state of grave sin, one rejects Christ and His covenant, therefore making a mockery of His covenant to the Church. The same can be said for those who partake in the Sacrament who profess rejection of what it is. Since the Sacrament is the real, literal Body and Blood of Christ, anyone who eats of it with a different understanding of this fact casts judgment on himself for his refusal to trust in Christ's own words, the words of eternal life.

“²⁷Whoever, therefore, eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty concerning the body and blood of the Lord. ²⁸Let a person examine himself, then, and so eat of the bread and drink of the cup. ²⁹For anyone

who eats and drinks without discerning the body eats and drinks judgment on himself.” (*ESV*, 1 Corinthians 11:27-29).

One must examine himself to ensure that his relationship with God is firm before he enters into the banquet of love prepared for the Church. If he rejects the orthodox teachings of the real presence of Christ in the elements, a teaching affirmed by the Christian Church throughout the centuries, he is merely separating his own soul even farther away from the Church which he neglects and from the God whom he does not trust.